

Constructing Grounded Theory

2nd Edition

Kathy Charmaz



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CONSTRUCTING GROUNDED THEORY (INTRODUCING QUALITATIVE METHODS SERIES)

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6

Focused Coding and Beyond

Our initial codes give us possible paths to take our analyses. But which one shall we take? Through studying and comparing our codes, we choose telling initial codes or devise a code that subsumes numerous initial codes. We treat these codes as focused codes to examine large batches of data. Focused coding directs our analysis early in the research process and helps us to evaluate the directions we take without embarking on a path of no return. While engaging in focused coding, we typically concentrate on what we define as the most useful initial codes and then we test them against extensive data. Subsequently, we may follow special procedures to elaborate our codes or move to extant theoretical codes if indicated by our emerging analysis. Signposts and guides make our sojourn with coding accessible and ease our way around obstacles.

Engaging in focused coding is the second major phase in coding. These codes appear more frequently among your initial codes or have more significance than other codes. In focused coding you use these codes to sift, sort, synthesize, and analyze large amounts of data. Focused coding requires decisions about which initial codes make the most analytic sense to categorize your data incisively and completely. It also can involve coding your initial codes.

Focused coding means using the most significant and/or frequent earlier codes to sift through and analyze large amounts of data. Focused coding requires decisions about which initial codes make the most analytic sense to categorize your data incisively and completely. It also can involve coding your initial codes.

Focused coding expedites your analytic work enormously without sacrificing the detail contained in your data and initial codes. This type of coding condenses and sharpens what you have already done because it highlights what you find to be important in your emerging analysis.

Focused codes advance the theoretical direction of your work. These codes are often more conceptual than many initial word-by-word, line-by-line, and incident-with-incident codes (Glaser, 1978). After you have established some strong analytic directions through your initial coding, you can begin focused coding to synthesize, analyze, and conceptualize larger segments of data.

BOX 6.1**Focused Grounded Theory Coding***

Examples of Codes	Narrative Data to be Coded
	<i>Could you talk about the ease... maybe... or difficulty... in the actual physical recovery?</i>
Being immobilized	It was horrible. I remember the instant I woke up from the surgery. And the surgery was supposed to take, maybe, three hours... it ended up taking something like six, maybe seven hours, because they didn't expect to find the spreading. I woke up...and... well, anesthesia has an interesting effect on people. I'd seen people come out of anesthesia before, and it's funny sometimes... people just start bawling and talking gibberish. Naturally, I wake up and I just start wailing crying. But I realize, first thing, that my voice is coming out much better than it had before surgery, so I thought, 'yeah, this is great!' The following weeks, I was in a lot of pain, primarily because of the nature of the surgery. For a thyroidectomy, there's a period of healing, of course, but my surgery was different because they had to go to the side of my neck where the tumor had begun to spread. As a result, I couldn't walk, could barely move... I was in bed for a good three weeks. I'm not the sort that can be bedridden easily. So I was miserable, and more unfortunate, I had to stay with my parents. My mother was fine... she doted on me a bit too much for my taste, but it was no surprise. But I could have done without my dad being there, and he was there plenty. And my condition didn't mean we didn't argue, which just complicated things with my voice. Following the surgery, there was a notable inability to speak well for about a month, when my phonation was very definitively affected. Slowly, it started coming back here and there, but something had definitely changed. I got everything checked, but no one could tell what changed. It's been theorized that the surgery was responsible for shifting some things around, so things were just going to be different from that point on. That was difficult... healing physically and coming to terms with the fact that things would have to be so different from then on... I wasn't even myself anymore after that. My voice was gone, so I was gone, and I'd never been anything but my voice. So yeah, that was really hard.
Feeling miserable	
Externalizing her inability to speak coherently	
Experiencing altered speech	
Defining certain impairment	
Defining permanent loss	
Experiencing forced loss	
Voice and self merge; losing a valued self	
Acknowledging suffering	

* See Charmez (2011a).

[Box 6.1](#) provides focused codes I defined after assessing the initial codes from same interview excerpt (see [Box 5.1](#) in [Chapter 5](#), p. 000). I highlighted 'voice and self merge' and 'losing a valued self.' These codes shaped the subsequent analysis. Defining loss of self by the participants themselves was explicit in the data that I used from the psychology demonstration project. Loss of self was present but remained implied in much of my data from studies of people with chronic illness. Losing a valued self became one of two fundamental processes on which I focused. The data also contained many statements that fit my focused code of 'regaining a valued self.' Subsequently, the analysis dealt with both processes. I wove codes together to form an explicit analysis of these two processes and distinguished between loss and disruption of self. My analysis of regaining a valued self in these data quickly centered on the intentional effort the research participants made to make a comeback and thus regain their earlier selves.

Focused Coding in Practice

Focused coding is usually straightforward and proceeds quickly. As my comments above suggest, it is a matter of studying and assessing your initial codes. Yet focused coding means more than simply selecting and going forward with the codes that most interest you. Rather, it means concentrating on what your initial codes say and the comparisons you make with and between them. Like your coding itself, what the codes say relies on how

you define their meanings. You are a part of your analytic work. You bring your analytic skills and perspectives to bear on the analysis throughout the research process – and that can be a gift.

Keep your involvement in mind as you proceed. It helps if you take a critical as well as measured stance toward your analytic practices. Focused coding involves attending to how your initial codes account for your data. Look for what these codes imply as well as what they reveal. Granted, what you define the codes as implying and revealing may represent widely shared definitions. But your definitions might represent a unique view that you bring to the analysis. And perhaps your codes lead you to make a phenomenon explicit that many people experience or witness but had not yet conceptualized. Your focused codes may lead you in unanticipated but exciting directions.

Perhaps your codes lead you to make a phenomenon explicit that many people experience or witness but had not yet conceptualized. Your focused codes may lead you in unanticipated but exciting directions.

Engaging in focused coding brings you further into the comparative process. One goal of focused coding is to determine the adequacy and conceptual strength of your initial codes. Assessing your initial codes involves comparing them with data and distinguishing those codes that have greater analytic power. Thus, you also compare codes with codes and think about the ones that may be promising tentative categories. Likely you wrote memos earlier in which you made and checked some of these

comparisons. Comparing codes with codes heightens your sense of the direction your analysis is going and clarifies the theoretical centrality of certain ideas. The following list may help you define which codes could serve best as focused codes.

- **What do you find when you compare your initial codes with data?**
- **In which ways might your initial codes reveal patterns?**
- **Which of these codes best account for the data?**
- **Have you raised these codes to focused codes?**
- **What do your comparisons between codes indicate?**
- **Do your focused codes reveal gaps in the data?**

Answers to these questions often come so quickly that you do not need to dwell on the questions. In this event, you already have the answers for the project at hand. For another project, you may need to do more comparative work to ascertain which codes will serve as focused codes and thus may become tentative categories. Attending to focused coding through making informed choices from your initial codes can give you the skeleton of your analysis. In addition, attending to focused coding can increase your confidence in your emerging analysis.

In [Box 6.2](#) on the following page, Kris Macomber (2011) shows us some of her focused codes (see also Macomber's initial codes and comments in [Box 5.5](#)) in another interview excerpt from her study of feminist advocates' views of men joining the movement to stop violence against women.

Here Macomber reveals that the women in the movement face a dilemma that they cannot resolve. The interview excerpt

and its corresponding codes portray the tensions these women experience. Macomber's codes delineate points that she can connect and elaborate in memos.

Focused coding is a significant step in organizing how you treat data and manage your emerging analysis. By attending to your initial codes and making decisions about focused codes, you trim away the excess for now (although you may go back to it later or write a separate paper or chapter on it). The move from initial to focused coding is often seamless. For most of my analyses, focused coding simply meant using certain initial codes that had more theoretical reach, direction, and centrality and treating them as the core of my nascent analysis.

In [Box 6.3](#) on page 143, Robert Thornberg provides an example from his study of bullying with his colleagues (see Thornberg, Halldin, Bolmsjö & Petersson, 2013). His focused codes portrayed in this box are ones he selected from his initial codes (see Thornberg & Charmaz, 2012).

Note how Thornberg's focused codes fit tightly with his data. They make immediate sense. They also provide the makings of a frame for the later analysis. Rather than using these focused codes as the final frame, however, Thornberg et al. (2013) developed an analysis of processes involved in becoming a victim of school bullying and in extricating self from it. They used the focused codes in this excerpt in service of related categories. Thus, the authors noted that being defined as deviant was part of the initial attacks and treated their code 'self-inhibiting,' as part of a self-protective strategy. In addition, they constructed an intriguing major category, "double victimizing" [which] refers to an interplay and cycling process between external victimizing

and internal victimizing' (pp. 6–7).

We think of focused coding as following initial coding. But moving to focused coding is not entirely a linear process. Some respondents or events will make explicit what was implicit in earlier statements or events. An 'Aha! Now I understand,' experience may prompt you to study your earlier data afresh. Then you may return to earlier respondents and explore topics that had been glossed over, unstated, or may have been too implicit to discern initially.

BOX 6.2

Kris Macomber's Focused Coding

During focused coding, I compared cases and doing so captured the duality (not just the complexity) of women's experiences that my data were recording. Women were not merely 'critiquing' men, nor were they simply undecided about their involvement. Focused coding captured how women are struggling to resolve the micro-political *dilemma* men's involvement creates for them. On the one hand, they support the benefits men's involvement brings. On the other hand, they contest the privilege and inequality it reproduces. Despite my initial assumption that individual women either supported or rejected men's involvement, focused coding illuminated how women simultaneously support and reject men's involvement. In presenting this dilemma, women articulated a tautological evaluation of men's involvement.

Focused Coding

Unable to resolve dilemma	Excerpt 2, Mel, female anti-rape educator and trainer I will talk myself into a circle on this one. I readily admit that now. We need men in this work. We're talking about men's violence against women, so we need men. Ok, and then here's where I start going around in a circle. Then I say to myself, but, isn't it frustrating that if I'm a man and you're a woman and we go into a class and say the exact thing to the men in the class, the reality is that since I'm a man they take my word for it without questioning it. But you are viewed as a man hating, angry, lesbian, feminist and all the other things [we] have been called forever. And...isn't that still part of the problem? But, then I say to myself, but if we can still reach those men and get the message out there...about how rape impacts women...and then round and round I go. Yes, we need them as allies. We need them out there doing the work with us. But I get very frustrated, quite honestly, that, excuse me, but this big fuckin' deal is made because of what they're saying. Well, we as women have been saying that for 30, 40, 60 years now, so just because you have a penis and you say it, this big to-do is made? That very clearly makes me angry, because I just said the 'I' word.
Conflicted feelings; circular thinking Identifying inconsistent thinking	
Identifying contradiction; contesting male privilege Supporting benefits of men's involvement; conflicted feelings circular thinking; supporting men's involvement	
Contesting male privilege Political contradiction	
Awareness of emotional arousal	

The strength of grounded theory coding derives from this type of concentrated, active involvement in the process. You interact with and act upon your data rather than passively read them. Through your actions, new threads for analysis become apparent. Events, interactions, and perspectives come into analytic purview that you had not thought of before. Focused coding also checks your preconceptions about the topic.

BOX 6.3

Focused Coding: Robert Thornberg's Study of Bullying

Focused Coding	Interview Statement
Deviance-defining and breaking-down of self by peers	Anna: It was that I was a bit different, and then, you know, they started to call me names. I don't remember exactly what. Interviewer: Different? How? Anna: Well, that I was more outgoing than most of the others and stuff. And they thought that you shouldn't really be like that. But I was like that so they thought I had to be broken down or stuff like that. So I stopped talking. Interviewer: How long did it go on before...? Anna: That was basically the whole junior level of the elementary school. During the third grade, I really didn't dare to talk to people. I was very shy then. Interviewer: But at the same time you report that you have lost a lot of...? Anna: Yeah, you know, all these years you didn't dare to stand up for yourself, and you kind of just take it in and somehow thought that you are worthless. There is so much time you have lost... that you have might done more fun stuff. Instead you have walked about and felt that you don't deserve to live.
Self-inhibiting	
Self-inhibiting	
Developing self-worthlessness	
Suffering loss of time	

From Thornberg and Charmaz (2012, p. 49). The excerpt and the codes are examples from the focused coding that preceded the results in Thornberg et al., 2013.

Consistent with the logic of grounded theory, both initial and focused coding are emergent processes. Unexpected ideas emerge. They can keep emerging. After you code a body of data, compare your codes and data with each other. A telling code that you constructed to fit one incident or statement might illuminate another. An earlier incident may alert you to see a subsequent one with incisiveness. Your coding may uncover such incidents or you may observe them unfolding while you are interviewing or in the field. I had witnessed several tense moments with couples during which one of the pair declared that their partner's disabilities robbed him or her of former competencies.

Consider the following fieldnotes from an early interview with Andrei, a retired college professor, and his wife, Natasha, both of whom had chronic illnesses:

I asked [Andrei], 'Did you keep up with professional work after you retired?' He said: 'I used to teach extension courses but due to the budget and that governor, there isn't any money for extension courses.' She [Natasha] cut in [to me], 'Andrei used to be an extremely successful speaker; partly his enthusiasm, partly his articulateness, but with the speech problems, he can't do it ...' [He said, slowly and painfully] 'The schools don't have any money ... I can't speak very well.'

I felt desperately sorry for him at this point. Whether or not both factors were at play at the point when they stopped calling him for extension teaching, this was a terrible moment for him when she said it. Regardless of the real reason, at this precise moment knowing what she thought of his deteriorating competence was critical to

him. Participating in this short sequence was like watching someone who was observing his own identity crumbling away – it was painful both for him and for me, although I got the impression that she was so caught up in her perceptions of accuracy that she didn't actually see how it defaced him. ... Acknowledging that he can't speak very well was said like an admission of guilt or inferiority that was previously hidden from view. (Charmaz, 1983a, pp. 119–120)

From such early observations, I developed the code of 'identifying moment.' In each case, the judgment imparted a shocking image of who the ill person had become. Such disquieting views proclaimed negative changes and underscored their permanence. The 'identifying moment' code alerted me to other brief interactions in which someone conferred a significant identity on a person with chronic illness.

Through comparing data with data, we develop the code. Then we compare data with these codes, which helps to refine them. Prior to interviewing Andrei, I compared situations in which participants had freely discussed their disabilities, with those situations in which they had not. Before the incident above, Andrei's physician had told me that his impaired speech was never openly discussed. I also compared such incidents for their intensity and impact. At first, the code only represented negative identifying moments. As I obtained more data, I found and defined positive identifying moments. 'Identifying moments' began as a code, which I developed as a category (Charmaz, 1991a). Because the notion of identifying moments resonates with many experiences, Will van den Hoonaard (1997) treats it



as a sensitizing concept for other researchers to use as a starting point.

Focused coding involves making decisions, but these decisions are tentative, not binding. You have the flexibility to pursue the codes that prove to be fruitful and to put aside ones that are not. In many cases, the codes that you work with during focused coding will become sections of your finished analysis.

Might you think that there must be more in the data than your initial codes reveal? If so, take these codes and ask this question: what kinds of theoretical categories do these codes indicate?

Might you think that there must be more in the data than your initial codes reveal? If so, take these codes and ask this question: what kinds of theoretical categories do these codes indicate?

This question can spark new ideas and spur you to conceptualize material that you had under-theorized. Because initial codes serve multiple tasks, some of your codes likely remain descriptive. Focused coding moves you out of immersion in data and brings you further into analysis. The added distance that focused coding affords can make conceptualizing these codes easier. Furthermore, you gain greater theoretical sensitivity as you work with ideas and raise questions about your data and earlier codes.

Sometimes students believe that the same code must reappear time and again to be used as a focused code and subsequently a possible category. Not at all. If the code is telling, use it.

Occasionally, you will craft a code that explains much more than the data from which you constructed it. The code can give you a flash of insight, a way of looking at your data. It's exhilarating! Allow these moments of exhilaration to occur.

In [Box 6.4](#), one code, 'suffering as a moral status,' is more abstract than the others and less tightly anchored to the data. Notice that Christine, the interviewee, does not say anything about either suffering or moral status. Those are my terms from interpreting the data and piecing together implicit meanings to make them visible. This code occurred to me while coding Christine's interview, long after I had coded numerous other interviews. Making such inferences while coding is one way in which you raise the analytic level of your work, but the data must support your inferences.

BOX 6.4

Focused Coding

Focused Coding	Interview Statement
Going against medical advice	And so I went back to work on March 1st, even though I wasn't supposed to. And then when I got there, they had a long meeting and they said I could no longer rest during the day. The only time I rested was at lunch time, which was my time, we were closed. And she said, my supervisor, said I couldn't do that anymore, and I said, 'It's my time, you can't tell me I can't lay down.' And they said, 'Well you're not laying down on the couch that's in there, it bothers the rest of the staff.' So I went around and I talked to the rest of the staff, and they all said, 'No, we didn't say that, it was never even brought up.' So I went back and I said, 'You know, I just was talking to the rest of the staff, and it seems that nobody has a problem with it but you,' and I said, 'You aren't even here at lunch time.' And they still put it down that I couldn't do that any longer. And then a couple of months later one of the other staff started laying down at lunch time, and I said, you know, 'This isn't fair. She doesn't even have a disability and she's laying down,' so I just started doing it.
Suffering as a moral status	
Making a moral claim	
Having a devalued moral status because of physical suffering	
Making a case for legitimate rights	
Seeing injustice Making claims for moral rights of personhood	

From Charmez (2001).

My earlier interviews had contained codes such as 'being stigmatized,' 'loss of self,' 'losing credibility,' 'feeling devalued', although I did not anchor them in an analysis of injustice, legitimacy, and suffering. I had discerned relationships between stigma, loss of self, and suffering much earlier (Charmaz, 1983b) and realized that much suffering derived from how other people treated those with chronic illnesses, but I focused on loss of self rather than on developing an explicit analysis of suffering.

Nonetheless those earlier codes nagged me. Yes, people routinely talked about experiences of being stigmatized, losing credibility, feeling devalued and the like. I had many related codes

emanating from similar experiences. The codes fit what was happening in the data. Did these codes reflect all that occurred? No. What else was happening? What were these codes getting at? What did research participants imply with their stories represented by these codes? Are these codes interchangeable indicators of something else? Perhaps. But what?

Constructing the 'suffering as a moral status' code was a breakthrough moment for me. I immediately realized that this code explained far more than what I was defining in the specific interview. I also realized that this code answered questions I had had about my earlier codes. To me 'suffering as a moral status' supplied a deeper, more incisive analytic handle on what I had coded. In this case, the code made explicit what I had sensed and understood but had not conceptualized. Before constructing the code, I had no adequate words to capture and crystallize the stories I was hearing and reading in the transcribed interview texts.

Through grappling with Christine's interview, my coding congealed around relationships between moral status and legitimacy, rights, and personhood. Christine's interview gave me the cues and the codes to look at other interviews. I found numerous stories that spoke to a person's moral status in families and friendships as well as at work. I also found ample evidence of suffering when a person believed his or her moral status had been diminished.

The theoretical import of a code such as 'suffering as a moral status' comes through in the code itself. The code emerged through my engagement with the data. Experiencing a significant theoretical insight while coding reflects what can

occur when you enter an interactive space with your data. By interacting with fragments of data, I came to see these data and what the person experienced in new light. My new view generated a substantially more abstract code that explained a number of the earlier codes and the described incidents those codes represented. This code is not something I applied later or perused the literature to find.

In this case, I happened to come up with the code during an initial coding of an interview after working with many materials about experiencing chronic illness. It is quite possible that you will construct a new code with greater theoretical reach and centrality during focused coding.

The moral of this story about 'suffering as a moral status' contains a message for you: allow yourself to raise the analytic level of one or more codes, *when your data indicate it*. Subsequently, check how and to what extent the code fits other data. You may already have a fund of data that fit your new analytic code. If you do not have other data, this code can lead you to asking new questions and gathering further data as you proceed, so that you can discern the relative usefulness of the code. In short, when you see that earlier codes speak to a more abstract code, construct one.

Allow yourself to raise the analytic level of a code, when your data indicate it. Subsequently, check how and to what extent this code fits other data.

Initial and focused coding will suffice for many projects. Once

you have your focused codes, you can work with what you find in them and the patterns they suggest. The coding excerpt beginning this chapter exemplifies an analysis that only used initial and focused coding. Keep coding simple. If you have the makings of a solid analysis with a small number of focused codes, then proceed with the analysis – and enjoy working on it.

Axial Coding

Strauss and Corbin (1990, 1998; Strauss, 1987) present a third type of coding, *axial coding*, to relate categories to subcategories. Axial coding specifies the properties and dimensions of a category. Thus proponents see it as a way of making coding – and the resulting analysis – more systematic. Axial coding has received some accolades and considerable criticism. Although Corbin (Corbin & Strauss, 2008) does not emphasize axial coding in the recent third edition of *Basics of Qualitative Research*, a number of researchers still profess to use it, so I briefly discuss it here.

Researchers who follow earlier editions of *Basics of Qualitative Research* (Strauss and Corbin, 1990, 1998) often adopt its complicated coding procedures to generate themes (Ball, Perkins, Whittington, Frank, & King, 2009; Morrow & Smith, 1995; Sakamoto, Chin, Chapra & Ricciar, 2009; Ullman & Townsend, 2008). Sarah Ullman and Stephanie Townsend's (2008) coding procedures generated themes such as 'definitions of feminist/empowerment approaches,' 'importance of control,' 'techniques for empowerment,' and 'advocate versus agency orientations' rather than a theory or conceptualized process.

Strauss (1987, p. 64) views axial coding as building ‘a dense texture of relationships around the “axis” of a category.’ Thus, axial coding follows the development of a major category, although it may be in an early stage of development. The purposes of axial coding are to sort, synthesize, and organize large amounts of data and reassemble them in new ways after open coding (Creswell, 1998).

Axial coding relates categories to subcategories, specifies the properties and dimensions of a category, and reassembles the data you have fractured during initial coding to give coherence to the emerging analysis.

During initial coding you fracture data into separate pieces and construct distinct codes. Axial coding is Strauss and Corbin's (1998) strategy for bringing data back together again in a coherent whole. According to Strauss and Corbin (p. 125), axial coding answers questions such as ‘when, where, why, who, how, and with what consequences.’ With these questions, a researcher can describe the studied experience more fully, although Corbin and Strauss contend that linking relationships between categories occurs on a conceptual rather than descriptive level. For them, analyzing data means converting text into concepts, which seems to be the intent of Strauss and Corbin's use of axial coding. These concepts specify the dimensions of a larger category. Axial coding aims to link categories with subcategories, and asks how they are related. Adele Clarke views axial coding as elaborating a category and uses diagramming to integrate

relevant categories.¹ For her, an integrative diagram aims to link categories with categories to form a substantive theory of action.

While engaged in axial coding, Strauss and Corbin apply a set of scientific terms to make links between categories visible. They group participants' statements into components of an organizing scheme to answer their questions above. In one such organizing scheme, Strauss and Corbin include: *conditions*, the circumstances or situations that form the structure of the studied phenomena; *actions/interactions*, participants' routine or strategic responses to issues, events, or problems; and *consequences*, outcomes of actions/interactions. Strauss and Corbin use conditions to answer the why, where, how come, and when questions (p. 128). Actions/interactions answer by whom and how questions. Consequences answer questions on ‘what happens’ because of these actions/interactions.

Axial coding provides a frame for researchers to apply. The frame may extend or limit your vision, depending on your subject matter and ability to tolerate ambiguity. Researchers who prefer to work with a preset structure will welcome having a frame. Those who prefer simple, flexible guidelines – and can tolerate ambiguity – do not need to do axial coding. Instead, they can follow the leads that they define in their empirical materials.

Although I have not used axial coding according to Strauss and Corbin's formal procedures, I have developed subcategories of a category and showed the links between them as I learned about the experiences the categories represent. My approach differs from axial coding in that my analytic strategies are *emergent*, rather procedural applications. The subsequent categories, subcategories, and links reflect how I made sense of the data.

The earlier coding example from Bonnie Presley's interview indicates that telling other people about having a chronic illness poses emotional and interactional dilemmas. Such dilemmas arose in many interviews; I had not planned to study them. Not surprisingly, the first two categories that I saw in early interviews were disclosing illness and avoiding disclosure. I outlined their respective properties through comparing data with data of the same kind of experience or event. The apparent pain in participants' stories led me to view 'disclosing' as revealing and often risky. Bonnie Presley's risks included exacerbating a medical crisis. Many other people risked making themselves emotionally vulnerable and having uncontrollable feelings. Disclosing was not a neutral form of talking.

Next, I re-examined the data I had coded during initial coding. Participants dealt with information about themselves both by avoiding disclosure of illness and by telling people about it; however, some forms of telling lacked control and sometimes not telling at all occurred when participants felt overwhelmed. When participants' lacked control in telling, they exposed themselves by blurting out their concerns instead of managing and metering self-revelations.

Subsequently, I coded for the range between spontaneous statements and staged pronouncements. I linked forms of telling explicitly to the relative absence or presence of participants' control in relaying information and the extent to which they invoked explicit strategies. After discovering that people invoked different forms of telling, I then looked more closely at the following:

- **Biographical and interactional contexts of their telling**
- **Social and experiential conditions affecting whom various participants told**
- **Participants' stated intentions for telling**
- **What participants told these individuals**
- **How participants told them.**

I coded for if, when, how, and why participants changed their earlier forms of telling. These strategies may lead to charting causes and conditions of the observed phenomenon. In my analysis of forms of telling (see [Figure 6.1](#)), studying these data led to seeing that the participant's subjective stake in telling exceeded what a researcher could plot along a simple continuum. Rather, subjectivity and objectivity meet when participants flaunt illness. It became apparent that some individuals flaunt illness when it has caused them unresolved problems of self-acceptance and acceptance by others.



Figure 6.1 Forms of Telling

No explicit frame guided my analytic constructions of participants' accounts and experiences or elicited the emphasis. Although axial coding may help researchers to explore their data, it encourages them to *apply* an analytic frame to the data.

Although axial coding may help researchers to explore their data, it encourages them to *apply* an analytic frame to the data.

In that sense, relying on axial coding may limit what and how researchers learn about their studied worlds and, thus, restricts the codes they construct.

Whether axial coding helps or hinders remains a question (see Kelle, 2005). Whether and to what extent it offers a more effective technique than careful comparisons remains debatable. Although many authors (see, for example, Hildenbrand, 2007) found Strauss and Corbin's coding procedures to be helpful, some did not (see, for example, Kendall, 1999; Urquhart, Lehmann, & Myers, 2010). Judy Kendall states: 'I became so distracted by working the model to its natural conclusion that I stopped thinking about what the data were telling me in regard to the research question' (p. 753).

At best, axial coding helps to clarify and to extend the analytic power of your emerging ideas. At worst, it casts a technological overlay on the data – and perhaps on your final analysis. Although intended to obtain a more complete grasp of the studied phenomena, axial coding can make grounded theory cumbersome (Robrecht, 1995).

Theoretical Coding: Application or Emergence?

Theoretical coding is a sophisticated level of coding that follows the codes you have selected during focused coding. Glaser (1978, p. 72) introduced theoretical codes as conceptualizing 'how the substantive codes may relate to each other as hypotheses to be integrated into a theory. They like substantive codes are emergent.' He reiterates this definition in 2005; however, he also applauds Phyllis Stern (1980, p. 23) for saying that theoretical coding 'simply means applying a variety of analytic schemes to the data to enhance their abstraction' (see Glaser, 2005, p. 5). As these statements indicate, the extent to which theoretical coding is an application or emergent process is somewhat ambiguous.

The extent to which theoretical coding is an application or emergent process is somewhat ambiguous.

The place of prior knowledge becomes ambiguous with theoretical codes. If theoretical codes are emergent, to what extent do they rely on prior knowledge? If emergence fosters creating new modes of thinking rather than reproducing the old, how might theoretical codes reflect new, fresh ways of integrating your codes and categories? Yet in *Theoretical Sensitivity* (1978), Glaser speaks to possessing prior knowledge in his discussion of theoretical codes. He writes: 'It is necessary for the grounded theorist to know many theoretical codes in order to be sensitive to rendering explicitly the subtleties of the relationships in his data' (p. 72).

Why use theoretical codes? The purpose of these codes is to help you theorize your data and focused codes. Theoretical codes are meant to be integrative; they lend form to the focused codes you have collected. These codes may help you tell an analytic story that has coherence. Hence, theoretical codes not only conceptualize how your substantive codes are related, but also may move your analytic story in a theoretical direction. Theoretical codes underlie your substantive codes and show relationships between them, rather than replace the substantive codes with ones constituting your theory. Glaser (1992) argues that theoretical codes preclude a need for axial coding because they 'weave the fractured story back together' (Glaser, 1978, p. 72).

Used wisely, theoretical codes can help you specify possible relationships between categories you have developed through focused coding. When merely applied, they impose a framework on your analysis and may encase it in an esoteric jargon. Unthinking application of theoretical codes can make your analysis opaque and impenetrable. A quick perusal of an article containing such codes can turn readers away. Nonetheless, some grounded theorists too frequently adopt them.

Knowledge of theoretical codes can lead to becoming circumspect as to how to use them. It can also foster applying these codes. In my analysis of losing and regaining a valued self, I made no explicit attempt to integrate my focused codes through theoretical coding. Instead, the direction of the analysis emerged from the participants' statements and their subsequent coding. Yes, theoretical notions about self and identity do surface in the analysis but they were not applied. I could have concentrated

solely on regaining a valued self, which would align the analysis with Glaser's current view of grounded theory: the study of how people resolve a problem in their lives. But this problem came from somewhere. Thus, accounting for losing a valued self became an important part of my analytic task. In my view, what you need to do emerges from the studied empirical world and the analytic sense you make of it.

The tension in theoretical coding lies precisely between emergence and application and, I believe, is yet to be resolved. How do you handle this tension? You might draw on the following sources: Glaser's (1978) 18 theoretical coding families; his additional, more recent codes (Glaser, 2005); theories from your discipline; and concepts from other fields. Glaser's early analytic categories include his 'Six Cs: Causes, Contexts, Contingencies, Consequences, Covariances, and Conditions' (p. 74), 'degree,' 'dimension,' 'interactive,' 'theoretical,' and 'type' coding families, as well as ones that derive from major concepts such as 'identity – self,' 'means – goals,' 'cultural,' and 'consensus' families. Several of Glaser's coding families indicate a specific analytic category but merge conceptual distinctions. For example, the 'unit' family includes the following structural units: group, family organizational, aggregate, territorial, societal, status and role units. Glaser also includes situations, social worlds and social contexts, which certainly may serve as units of analysis but connote emergent, rather than structural properties. In *Doing Grounded Theory* (1998), Glaser enlarges on several earlier coding families and extends the list to include more coding families such as: the 'paired opposite,' 'representation,'



'scale,' 'random walk,' 'structural-functional,' and 'unit identity' families.

If you use them skilfully, theoretical codes may hone your work with a sharp analytic edge. These codes can add precision and clarity – as long as they fit your data and substantive analysis.

If you use them skilfully, theoretical codes may hone your work with a sharp analytic edge. These codes can add precision and clarity – as long as they fit your data and substantive analysis.

Theoretical codes can aid in making your analysis coherent and comprehensible. Depending on the data and what you learn about them, your analysis may take into account several coding families. For example, you may clarify the general context and specific conditions in which a particular phenomenon is evident. It might be possible to specify the conditions under which this phenomenon changes and to outline its consequences. You may learn its temporal and structural orderings and discover participants' strategies for dealing with them. And if the temporal ordering is understandable, you likely include an analysis of process. Thus, despite not delving into substance, this short example alone brings in the following analytic coding families: the 'Six Cs,' 'temporal ordering,' 'ordering' (Glaser includes structural ordering here, see 1978, p. 78), 'strategy,' and 'process.' The links provided by the codes may also point to areas that you can strengthen.

Robert Thornberg (2010a) shows how children's accounts of

the reasons for bullying are social representations. The notion of social representations speaks to theoretical codes about social structure and collective representations that are widely shared and often understood as taken-for-granted truths. In the excerpt in [Box 6.5](#), see how Thornberg's interviews of children reflect and develop two types of social representations.

BOX 6.5

Thornberg on Bullying

Bullying as a Reaction to Deviance

The most prevalent social representation on bullying causes among the children in this study is to view *bullying as a reaction to deviance*....This social representation means that the victim is interpreted as deviant, different, or odd, which in turn provokes others to bully him or her.

Interviewer: *What do you think caused the bullying?*

Child: *Being different.*

Interviewer: *Different? What do you mean?*

Child: *Well, different clothes, and talking differently, looking different.*

Interviewer: *Can you tell a bit more about this? Looking different?*

Child: *Tall, short, fat, different styles of clothes and such things.*

(Interview with a 13-year-old boy) (2010a, p. 315)

Bullying as a Revengeful Activity

A fourth social representation on bullying causes is about explaining bullying in terms of revenge, payback, or punishment.... For example, he or she said something mean, was teasing, started a fight, was nasty to the bully's little brother, spread negative rumors, snitched and told teachers, and so on.

Child: He [victim] does something bad, and then he gets shit back.

Interviewer: *What could he have done?*

Child: Well, it could be that he asks if he can join in a game, and they say no to him, and then he...tells a teacher so you get a lot of telling-off. And then, the others usually think, 'well, that wasn't so smart [of him].' And then a lot of things happen during the lessons and we can't go outdoors and have breaks because of that.

Interviewer: *So it's like a bit of punishment then?*

Child: Yeah, and then the whole class gets it.

Interviewer: *Well, okay, but how come that the bullying occurs?*

Child: Well, because he [the victim] has done something or has started something, that he has said something.

(Interview with a 10-year-old boy) (2010a, p. 317)

Strauss's (1978a, 1993) work on social worlds and social arenas influenced Clarke (1998), who subsequently developed the concepts. In the following passage, she offers an explicit rationale for the theoretical concepts that emerged early in her research as an integrating coding family:

Social worlds and arenas analysis offers a number of analytic advantages in studies of disciplinary formation. First, and of special import in historical research, social worlds analysis bridges internal and external concerns by encompassing the involvement and contributions of all the salient social worlds. Both internal and external topics may be relevant. Social worlds are genuinely social units of analysis, elastic and plastic enough to allow very diverse applications. One can avoid misrepresenting collective social actors as monolithic by examining diversity within worlds, while still tracking and tracing their overall collective perspectives, ideologies, thrusts, and goals. One can comfortably analyze the work of particular individuals as important to the arena, without being limited to an individual approach. Perhaps most important, in the very framing of an arena,



one is analytically led to examine the negotiations within and between worlds that are most consequential for the development of the arena over time. (1998, p. 265)

Your earlier substantive analysis should indicate the kind of theoretical codes that you invoke. In short, like any other extant concept, theoretical codes must earn their way into your grounded theory (Glaser, 1978). Yet *how* grounded theorists assess which theoretical codes fit remains ambiguous. The outcome is clearer; grounded theorists tend to adopt concepts from their disciplines, or borrow them from another when their field lacks such concepts. When we look at how analytic styles and conceptual toolkits take hold in a discipline, we discover fads and trends among them. Such fads and trends limit ways of seeing and perhaps force data into old boxes.

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Glaser points out that over-reliance on the strategy coding family leads scholars to impute conscious intentions when participants may not hold them (p. 76). Similar problems arise with other theoretical codes. Glaser proposes: 'Perhaps the most frequent implicit rubric in studies is a problem of social order [usually disorder]' (p. 78). Yet counter-arguments proclaim that enlisting the concept of 'disorder' prevents researchers from

seeing alternative social structural forms. Marxists have long argued that the consensus model precludes seeing conflict and domination. Some symbolic interactionists have applied such concepts as 'career,' 'work,' 'negotiation,' and 'strategy' wholesale to their studies (Charmaz, 2005).

If so, the chosen concept may preclude attending to emergence of other possible theoretical codes. Theoretical codes centering on strategizing, for example, can preclude attending to actions that do not aim to control other people and also leave out spontaneity, whimsy, and happenstance. Erving Goffman's (1959, 1967, 1969) work exemplifies a strategic model of interaction and its corresponding assumption that individuals aim to control encounters:

Regardless of the particular [interactional] objective which the individual has in mind and of his motive for having this objective, it will be in his interests to control the conduct of the others, especially their responsive treatment of him. This control is achieved largely by influencing the definition of the situation which the others come to formulate, and he can influence this definition by expressing himself in such a way as to give them the kind of impression that will lead them to act voluntarily in accordance with his own plan. Thus, when an individual appears in the presence of others, there will usually be some reasons for him to mobilize his activity so that it will convey an impression to others which it is in his interests to convey. (1959, pp. 3–4)

In the passage above, you see Goffman's explicit concern with strategy and control. Often the theoretical integration provided by theoretical codes remains implicit in the analysis. For example, symbolic interactionism informs my study of people with chronic illness, *Good Days, Bad Days: The Self in Chronic Illness and Time* (1991a), but remains in the background. The substantive analysis of how people experience illness takes the foreground in the book and, thus, comes across most strongly. The codes that arose from symbolic interactionist sensibilities give a theoretical foundation or conceptual infrastructure that integrates the narrative. Readers from other disciplines may remain unaware of the implicit theoretical frame that organizes a given piece of work. For example, the connections between time and self are clear in the following example, although not every reader will see their links to symbolic interactionism.

A desire to recapture the past reflects yearning for a lost self. That yearning results from grieving for accumulated losses from illness. Here, the person defines losses and acknowledges illness. Though she writes that she learned to live moment by moment after her stroke, poet May Sarton simultaneously longed for her past self: 'Now I am frightfully lonely because I am not my self. I can't see a friend for over a half-hour without feeling as though my mind were draining away like air rushing from a balloon'. (1988, p. 18)

The sorrow for a past self increases when people believe that they might not reclaim it. Even after trying to wait out illness or treatment, regaining the past self and recapturing the past may remain elusive. Sarton suggests

this elusiveness when she writes that 'to manage such a passive waiting life for so many months I have had to bury my real self – and now realize that bringing back that real self is going to be even more difficult than it was to bury it'. (1988, p. 78) (Charmaz, 1991a, p. 194)

Sarton's lament reflects the idea that one's self-concept has boundaries and content, as a symbolic interactionist would argue. Our self-concepts provide a way of knowing ourselves, a way of separating what is ours and what is distinct from us. Sarton shows us that her self-concept remains in the past and now is at odds with the images of self given in her current predicament.

What stands as a theoretical coding family? Glaser (1978, 2005) does not supply criteria for establishing what we should accept as a coding family or reasons why we should accept his depiction of them. He states that his list of coding families contains overlapping categories and points out that a new coding family can arise from a pre-existing one. As Glaser acknowledges, his coding families are neither exhaustive nor mutually exclusive. Nor are they reflective of the same level and type of abstraction. Some coding families refer to recognizable analytic terms and some draw on sociological concepts. The names of several coding families, such as 'interactive,' 'reading,' 'mainline,' seem arbitrary and vague (see Glaser, 1978, pp. 76–81). Their meanings as well as those of others remain embedded in the narrative. 'Interactive' refers to 'mutual effects,' 'reciprocity,' 'mutual dependency,' and the like, rather than to interaction *per se*. The 'reading family' includes 'concepts,' 'problems,' and



'hypotheses.' The 'mainline family' includes a sweeping array of structural concepts and concerns such as 'social institutions,' and 'social order,' along with 'socialization,' 'social interaction,' and 'social worlds,' which Glaser also lists in the unit family.

Several conceptual families are noticeably absent in Glaser's list, including those that focus on agency and action, power, networks, and narrative and biography. Others such as inequality remain buried in a larger unit. Conflict is relegated to the larger family of consensus, indicating a subordination that conflict theorists would rightfully and vigorously contest. More recently, theoretical currents such as feminist theory and cultural studies generate other theoretical codes. Glaser acknowledges that new coding families may emerge from earlier ones. Many of his additions hearken back to positivist concepts.

How might ordinary grounded theory coding compare with axial coding and using theoretical codes? Think about the preceding discussion and the forms of telling in [Figure 6.1](#). The types of telling themselves might be seen as dimensions of the larger category of telling. Each type has particular properties and reflects views of self and identity as well as immediate interactional circumstances. In one sense, the types reflect a range from subjectivity to objectivity along a continuum. The types differed by degrees in the following areas: felt emotional intensity, difficulty in telling, emotional and informational control in the telling, amount and kind of planning, and intended audience effect. A number of participants found that their forms of telling differed at various points in their illness. When people felt shocked by a diagnosis or first episode of illness, they blurted out the news without control. If they felt demeaned or devalued

for having told their news, then they became more measured in their telling and may move from spontaneous disclosing to measured informing. When episodes accrue and people discover costs of telling, they may resort to occasional strategic announcing. Although many people may become strategic about how, when, where, and to whom they disclose, relatively few engage in flaunting. From this brief discussion, you can see how studying processes can shape an analysis. Note that a consequence of one type of telling can set the conditions for a person to engage in another.

The kinds of links in the preceding example emerged as I studied my data about imparting illness news. Quite possibly further in-depth data or additional comprehensive data about forms of telling would lead to more links. Now a word of caution. These theoretical codes may lend an aura of objectivity to an analysis, but the codes themselves do not stand as some objective criteria about which scholars would agree or that they could uncritically apply. When your analysis indicates, use theoretical codes to help you clarify and sharpen your analysis but avoid imposing a forced framework on it with them. It helps to interrogate yourself about whether these theoretical codes interpret all the data. My advice? If you use theoretical codes, let them breathe through the analysis, not be applied to it.

Wrestling with Preconceptions

Throughout the grounded theory literature, researchers are enjoined to avoid forcing their data into preconceived codes and categories. Foremost among these are extant theories. We also



must guard against forcing our preconceptions on the data we code during every phase of coding. Engaging in reflexivity about preconceptions holds special significance in focused coding because these codes shape our analyses. The student who forced his own view of disability on his interview data imposed what sociologists call 'common sense theorizing' on his analysis (Schutz, 1932/1967). His reasoning arose from his notions of how the world works and from his own experience as a disabled man. Had he attended more closely to his codes, he might have identified his preconceptions.

Grounded theorists, like other researchers, may and do unwittingly start from their own preconceptions about what a particular experience means and entails. Preconceptions that emanate from such standpoints as class, race, gender, age, embodiment, culture, and historical era may permeate an analysis without the researcher's awareness. If so, these invisible standpoints linger outside the frame for discussing the analysis and remain fundamentally unproblematic for researchers who hold them. These researchers may deny their existence.²

Every researcher holds preconceptions that influence, but may not determine, what we attend to and how we make sense of it. Shadows of capitalism, competition, and individualism may enter Western social scientists' analyses without our realizing it because they frame the way we know the world. Erving Goffman's detailed fieldwork, keen observations, and compelling categories made him one of the most astute social scientists of the twentieth century. Nonetheless, Goffman's model of strategic interaction assumed an individualistic, competitive, strategic, and hierarchical concept of human nature that fit 1950s

North American cultural conceptions of white, upwardly mobile, middle-class men (Charmaz, 2004). Such taken-for-granted assumptions influence what we attend to and how we make sense of it. In the statement below, Goffman provides trenchant advice for conducting excellent ethnographic work. As incisive as his advice is, we also gain a glimpse of his preconceptions.

As graduate students, we're only interested in being smart, and raising our hands, and being defensive – as people usually are – and forming the right associations, and all that. And if you're going to do good fieldwork it seems to me that's got to go by the board. ...

You have to open yourself up in ways you're not in ordinary life. You have to open yourself up to being snubbed. You have to stop making points to show how 'smart-assed' you are. And that is extremely difficult for graduate students (especially on the East Coast). Then you have to be willing to be a horse's ass. (1989, pp. 127–128)

Our preconceptions may only become apparent when our taken-for-granted standpoints are challenged.

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Rosanna Hertz (2003) faced such challenges 20 years after her ethnographic study of a kibbutz when the son of a couple in the kibbutz asked to live with her. Through his presence, she discovered that this family had defined her relationship to them



as ‘family’ and she had seen it as a ‘transaction’ bounded by her now long-past stay in the kibbutz. Hertz states that she realized ‘how tricky perception is and how deeply rooted assumptions and ideological preferences can challenge even the most ardent efforts at openness’ (p. 474).

Becoming aware of your preconceptions as you engage in the iterative process of coding, memo-writing, and collecting data enriches your analysis. Gemma Carney (see Conlon et al., 2013) tells how her preconceptions surfaced during an interview for a team project in Ireland. The team had already conducted 23 interviews; this one was Carney’s eighth interview. By this time, the team was conducting simultaneous data collection, coding, and memo-writing and had developed some tentative ideas about solidarity between generations. Carney states:

It was only through speaking with a young, energetic woman, engaged enough to join a protest movement that I began to question my preconceptions of emigration in Ireland. Was emigration more insidious than I had first thought? Rosalind helped me to link disillusionment with the state to Irish people’s propensity to leave their home country. I began to interpret her views as demonstrating the role of emigration in establishing a permanently temporary social contract in Ireland. Emigration fractures family units and separates ‘being Irish’ from ‘living in Ireland.’ The option to emigrate is always there, having become ingrained in the psyche of a country that has repeatedly used emigration to survive hardships, including colonialism, famine, numerous recessions and latterly the worst negative

effects of globalisation. Without a permanent constituency of citizens like Rosalind, willing to fight to improve social, economic and political conditions, I began to see that solidarity between generations is both stronger and weaker than I had assumed. It is stronger in the sense that families do maintain close relationships despite living long distances apart. However, the Irish diaspora also leaves remainders: lost generations, and a fractured, temporary relationship between state and those citizens who stay behind. (p. 11)

Carney’s discovery of her preconceptions not only enriched her understanding but also contributed to the team’s emerging analysis. Should you have the good fortune to discover your preconceptions while engaged in the research process, welcome your new awareness. Your analysis will benefit from it.

Should you have the good fortune to discover your preconceptions while engaged in the research process, welcome your new awareness. Your analysis will benefit from it.

Our preconceptions may be shaken time and again during the research process. During her field research for her dissertation and subsequent book, *The Making of the Unborn Patient: A Social Anatomy of Fetal Surgery* (1998),³ Monica Casper realized that fetal surgery posed risks to both mother and fetus. She saw that the surgeons viewed the mother as a container for the fetus, the ‘real’ patient, a stance with which she disagreed. Casper makes

her starting points and perspectives explicit in the following statement:

I have spent a great deal of time and energy articulating the ways in which fetal surgery and its practitioners are political. Yet I have also had to be reflexive about my own politics and how they have shaped this research. As C. Wright Mills argued, 'there is no way in which any social scientist can avoid assuming choices of value and implying them in his [sic] work as a whole. ... No one is "outside society"; the question is where each stands within it.' ... My deep commitment to women's health issues and my reproductive rights philosophy generated my initial interest in fetal surgery. After beginning this project, I realized that moving from 'activist' to 'analyst' was not a simple endeavor; I could not just 'turn off' my politics once I entered the field. To assert that I could somehow manage to keep my politics separate from my research, while simultaneously exposing my informants' politics, would have been the height of methodological hypocrisy. (1997, pp. 240–241)

From the beginning, Casper's perspective on the implications of fetal surgery for women's reproductive health clashed with those of fetal surgeons whose views and work formed a significant part of her research. Unlike the experience of most qualitative researchers, Casper's early analytic work became known to those she criticized. After sharing a paper with one woman she had interviewed, the woman sent it to her surgical team. These surgeons confronted Casper about her beliefs and actions in

the field and forced her to take a reflexive stance. What made Casper's study such a powerful analysis is exactly what made it so difficult. She immersed herself in studying a contested problem controlled by elites and did so as a young, female graduate student.

In her book, Casper indicates the depth of her reflexive inquiry by saying, 'I have been moved and transformed by this research in multiple ways, and fetal surgery is something I shall continue to think and talk about long after this book is published. My politics and intellectual assumptions have been shaken time and again' (1998, p. 25). Long after publication of the book, Casper (2007) still questions what transpired during her research and afterwards, the savage responses of many fetal surgeons to her book:

What had I said or done that was so objectionable? I had been critical of surgeons and their lack of ethical reflection, to be sure, but I was also deeply concerned about fetal health and well-being. Surely we were roughly on the same side. Yet I had also positioned myself as an advocate for pregnant women, arguing for their safety, care, and autonomy while challenging many aspects of the procedure itself. In the end, I realized that my book had become caught up in the very politics about which I had written. The fetus in American culture is vociferously contested, and no discussion of the unborn is untainted by these politics. *The Making of the Unborn Patient* was yet another player in the ongoing battle to determine who gets to speak for the fetus, and for pregnant women. (p. 25)



Casper's searching questions hint at how our preconceptions can continue to be challenged and at how continued reflexivity about them can teach us to remain circumspect about our work. Her questions continued despite changes in fetal surgery over the intervening years, respectful integration of her policy recommendations at certain major medical institutions, and, shortly after its publication, receiving the most prestigious book award in her discipline.

Strategies for Revealing Preconceptions

Several strategies foster revealing preconceptions. Achieving intimate familiarity with the *studied phenomenon* is a prerequisite, as the research design of both Casper and Carney's projects fostered. Such familiarity not only includes an in-depth knowledge of people who contend with the phenomenon, but also a level of understanding that pierces their experience. This level moves you beyond taking the same things for granted that your respondents assume. Initial coding can move you in this direction by inducing you to wrestle with your participants' interpretive frames of reference, which may not be your own. Taking a reflexive stance toward challenges, as Hertz does above, may result in questioning one's perspectives and practices.

The grounded theory maxim about preconceived ideas earning their way into your analysis includes ideas from your previous studies. That means you do fresh heavy analytic work first, as I showed in the coding excerpts of losing a valued self. I have argued that earlier theoretical concepts may provide starting points for looking at your data but they do not offer

automatic codes *for* analyzing these data. If you apply theoretical concepts from your discipline at all, you must ensure that these concepts work. Several safeguards against imposing them may help. Consider these questions:

- **Do these concepts help you understand what the data indicate?**
- **If so, how do they help?**
- **Can you explicate what is happening in this line or segment of data with these concepts?**
- **Can you adequately interpret this segment of data without these concepts?**
- **What do these concepts add? What do they leave out?**

If extant concepts are not integral for understanding your data, they do not have a place in your codes or your later analysis. The best approach is for you to define what is happening in your data first.

Preconceptions work their way into how we think and write. Researchers who see themselves as objective social scientists or professionals often assume that their judgments of participants are correct. This stance can lead to treating your unexamined assumptions as fact. Be careful about applying a language of intention, motivation, or strategies *unless the data support your assertions*. You cannot assume what is in someone's mind – particularly if he or she does not tell you. And then should people tell you what they 'think,' remember that they provide statements reflecting social context, time, place, biography, situation, and audience. Participants' unstated purposes in



telling you what they 'think' may be more significant than their stated thoughts. If you reframe participants' statements to fit a language of intention, you are forcing the data into preconceived categories – yours, not theirs. Making comparisons between data about what people say and do, however, strengthens your assertions about implicit meanings.

A fine line exists between interpreting data and imposing a pre-existing frame on it. While coding, problems may arise by:

- **Coding at too general a level**
- **Identifying topics instead of actions and processes**
- **Overlooking how people construct actions and processes**
- **Attending to disciplinary or personal concerns rather than participants' concerns**
- **Coding out of context**
- **Using codes to summarize but not to analyze.**

During a grounded theory workshop, the participants engaged in a coding exercise with the same data from fieldnotes about professionals in a clinical setting. One participant coded almost every statement and described incident in the data as 'stress' – undifferentiated, unexamined stress, at that. Her reasons for seeing stress as significant were understandable; however, she was coding at too general a level with a topic that consumed her but did not take into account actions and processes in the fieldnotes. Other workshop participants whose codes stuck more closely to the data created a nuanced set of codes that synthesized what they saw happening in the data.

Take an examined stance about whose point of view your

codes reflect, which categories they indicate, and when you bring in abstract ideas. Such a stance toward coding fosters treating your ideas as problematic as well as those of your research participants. Consider using the following questions to check how you code:

- **How does my coding reflect the incident or described experience?**
- **Do my analytic constructions begin from this point?**
- **Have I created clear, evident connections between the data and my codes?**
- **Have I guarded against rewriting – and therefore recasting – the studied experience into a lifeless language that better fits *our* academic and bureaucratic worlds than those of our participants?**

Granted, we bring different views to the data we witness. We see things that our participants may not. As our codes become more abstract, we may couch them in analytic terms our participants do not share. They may, however, resonate with some codes such as the idea of an 'identifying moment' discussed above. Through illuminating experience, codes forge a bridge between described data and our emerging analysis.

Finally, another word about earlier grounded theory notions about erasing preconceptions. Early versions of grounded theory became marked by the insistence that researchers dispense with preconceptions about such issues as the research problem, earlier conceptions of it, research about the problem and theories to apply to it. Entering the research field with no preconceptions



became a dictum. But these versions of grounded theory remained remarkably silent about researchers' preconceptions emanating from their other positions and locations. Remaining open-minded about the research issues above forms a basic stance toward inquiry. Yet the notion of entering inquiry with no preconceptions is itself a preconception. This dictum can serve as an excuse for not examining fundamental preconceptions: what the researcher *takes for granted* about self, situation, and the world.

Concluding Thoughts

Both initial and focused coding present challenges, as I have outlined in the previous and present chapters. Coding also presents opportunities for rapid analytic development. Active involvement in coding is a key part of the grounded theory process. At first coding may seem labored but you may soon be amazed by your brisk pace. As your initial codes take analytic form, your focused coding quickens. Checking your focused codes against large batches of data makes the analytic process effective and efficient. And developing some of your focused codes may well be all you need.

Developing theoretical sensitivity will enable you to bring analytic precision to your work, whether or not you pursue constructing theory. Theoretical sensitivity and coding each influence the other. Theoretical sensitivity is the ability to understand and define phenomena in abstract terms and to demonstrate abstract relationships between studied phenomena. With this type of sensitivity, grounded theorists discern

meanings in their emergent patterns and define the distinctive properties of their constructed categories concerning these patterns. Thus, theoretical sensitivity enables grounded theorists to construct analytic codes leading to abstract concepts that have clear empirical indicators and can be distinguished from other concepts.

Theoretical sensitivity fosters going to the roots of studied life and specifying how it is constituted. Theoretical sensitivity increases the analytic power of your codes and engaging in coding stimulates developing theoretical sensitivity. Coding not only fragments your data, through coding you also learn what forms these data and in which theoretical directions you can take them. Implicit processes become visible. Connections between codes emerge. And your questions about your data grow more precise and penetrating.

My final comment echoes earlier guidelines but adds a promise. Keep your initial codes short, simple, spontaneous – and *analytic*. *The rest will fall in place.*

¹ Personal communication, September 20, 2004.

² Feminist standpoint theorists such as Dorothy Smith (1987), Nancy Hartsock (1998), and Patricia Hill Collins (1990) have made powerful arguments about hidden assumptions.

³ Casper's book exemplifies writing an outstanding grounded theory study for an educated general audience. She wrote a sophisticated but accessible analysis devoid of grounded theory jargon and structure. For a contrasting exemplar of clear writing and excellent analysis reflecting an explicit



grounded theory logic, see Suellen Miller's (1996) superb study of new mothers' strategies for re-entering careers. Miller adopted the notion of strategies to integrate the analysis for her doctoral research in nursing. Her report provides a nice example of how an often over-used code, "strategies," fits the studied data. Thus, beyond its exceptional contribution, her study is also instructive for assessing the fit between theoretical codes and data.

